

China Healthcare

Expert call takeaways: Pulse check on China's clinical CROs in Q226

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H126: Strong order recovery; mild price recovery in some segments

We hosted a senior executive from a domestic private clinical CRO on 13 July. He noted a continued strong recovery in domestic clinical CRO order intake in H126, with overall order volume up 20-30% YoY, mainly driven by an uptick in the number of innovative drug clinical trials, increased outsourcing demand from small biotech companies and eased competition following the exit of small/medium-sized CROs. He indicated prices did not rebound sharply in Q2, although quotes for some orders in data management/clinical services edged up 3-5% vs. significantly less services for low-priced bioequivalence (BE) trials. Also, as an essential segment, SMOs had a more meaningful price recovery, with the service fees/gross profit of awarded contracts up 5-10%. The expert expects order intake to continue outpacing pricing in H226, with pricing likely to maintain mild single-digit growth.

Limited geopolitical impact; actually closer global drug R&D ties

The expert thinks geopolitics had disruptions in sentiment for China's clinical CROs and innovative drugs going global, without changing the sector's going global trajectory. There is great uncertainty about whether proposals to restrict US regulators from accepting overseas clinical data can be implemented, while only a few companies may have concerns due to risk appetite. For one thing, the expert noted biotech companies' steady progress in overseas expansion, and many companies need ongoing R&D funding via out-licensing. For another, the expert believes China's clinical CROs have notable advantages in cost/patient enrolment speed, attracting overseas capital/global pharma firms to conduct early-stage clinical validation of targets in China. On this basis, the expert noted actually closer ties between global pharma and domestic CROs/pharma firms; the early trend shows domestic CROs are receiving more outsourcing orders from multinational companies, while they are following domestic innovative drug companies in overseas expansion.

AI helps clinical CROs raise efficiency; investing by traditional/AI-based CROs

The expert mentioned AI has become a key approach to improve efficiency in clinical CROs, although currently more as workflow tool upgrades, rather than revolutionary business model changes. He said domestic/overseas CROs, pharma firms and EDC vendors are investing in AI. Multinational CROs are working with external suppliers to develop AI platforms, with efficiency in some processes likely to improve c30-50%. Domestic CROs have relatively limited investment, usually c1-2% of revenue, and mostly for internal-use tools. He emphasized statistical programming, data management, pharmacovigilance, medical writing and medical translation will be the first to benefit. For example, statistical programming can compress 20-30 hours of work into less than one hour, and there is a lot of room to lift the productivity of data management and statistics teams. He sees a positive boost from AI to margins, although it is unlikely to significantly raise industry pricing in the near term. Also, avoiding result bias and strengthening manual quality control remain challenges in implementation, while on-site clinical execution roles, including CRA and CRC, are still unlikely to be fundamentally replaced over the next five years.

More details from the expert are provided below

The following pages contain key takeaways from the expert discussion, which are intended for investor reference only.

TRANSCRIPT HIGHLIGHTS

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1. Did the ASP and volume of domestic clinical CRO orders in Q2 improve further from Q1?

Expert: Order intake picked up significantly in Q226 vs. Q126, with c20-30% YoY growth in H126. Prices in general had no notable changes, with only some orders having mild price rises of 3-5%. The drug regulator's latest annual clinical trial report showed continued YoY growth in trial volume, with that of innovative drugs gaining c18% YoY in 2025 (mainly class 1 innovative drugs). Coupled with the exit of small and medium-sized CROs and eased competition, there was a broad-based order intake increase, with SMOs having the most significant recovery (service fees and gross profit of awarded contracts up c5-10%).

2. What types of orders had moderate price increases, and why?

Expert: Overall order intake picked up, while the supply-demand dynamics improved due to the exit of some competitors amid previous weakness. The released ICH E6 (R3) clinical trial guidelines have more stringent requirements for quality and follow-up management throughout the whole clinical trial process, further raising the requirements for CROs. Under this circumstance, scaled CROs have no sharp price cuts for order intake, as small CROs used to do. Currently, orders related to statistics have had mild price increases, while fewer companies are willing to accept low-priced orders, such as BE studies.

3. What is your outlook for order intake and pricing in H226? Has the industry entered a recovery phase?

Expert: The recovery trend is relatively clear, and capital investment in new drugs is no longer as cautious as in the past two years. Also, China now ranks first globally by clinical trial volume and second only to the US by overall environment (policy, pricing, research institutions and transparency) among major countries. Prices are only about one-third to one-half of those in the US, while patient enrolment speed is about five times that of the US. Faster enrolment and earlier results have also attracted some overseas biopharma firms to conduct trials or make enquiries in China. Looking ahead to H226, prices could maintain mild single-digit increases, while order intake growth could be faster.

4. Are there differences or new changes in demand from large pharma companies, and small, medium-sized and large biotech companies?

Expert: Leading pharma companies have a relatively high proportion of in-house teams for domestic clinical business (including SMOs), and only outsource a small number of MRCT projects to multinational CROs. Large and mature biotech companies have also shifted from outsourcing to in-house teams in recent years, and tend to outsource most IIT and RWS to domestic CROs. Therefore, domestic CROs mainly undertake orders from small biotech companies, with demand rising amid trial number increases, although the cash flow of the latter is not as healthy as for the first two groups. In addition, an early new trend is that multinational pharma companies began to outsource some China-based projects to larger, higher-quality domestic CROs. After years of development, domestic CROs have been on par with multinational CROs by scale and clinical trial quality; they have notable price advantages and are also more competitive in maintaining relationships with research institutions and principal investigators (PIs).

5. What progress has been made in domestic CROs' strategy of following innovative drug makers going global and undertaking overseas clinical trials?

Expert: Going global is an inevitable trend, and destinations are no longer limited to the US; inquiries about Europe, Japan, Southeast Asia and Hong Kong have increased notably. Among them, leading CROs building overseas footprints earlier have acquired local CROs in Japan and Southeast Asia and gained advantages, while most others collaborate with local partners. Out-licensing of domestic innovative drugs neared US \$140bn in 2025, with the value of deals in H126 outpacing that in H125. CROs are also following domestic innovative drug makers in going global.

6. How are industry margins trending? Besides price increases, are there any other factors?

Expert: Margins have recovered slightly YoY and vs. Q126, rising c5%. Besides price increases, the main driver is cost reduction and efficiency improvement. Labour utilisation has improved c15-20%, offsetting cost pressure arising from earlier price declines. AI has also contributed. For example, in statistical programming, tasks such as SDTM/ADaM mapping that previously required 20-30 hours can now be shortened to less than one hour with AI assistance.

7. If the US implements policies restricting the FDA from accepting China's clinical data and strengthening cross-border data review, what would be the implications?

Expert: Currently, there is still great uncertainty in whether such policies will be implemented and how large the impact would be. Chinese biopharma companies' out-licensing has a greater impact on overseas start-ups that follow a similar model of "early-stage clinical trials + out-licensing" (Chinese innovative drugs have lowered the licensing prices of such assets); this trend is actually positive for multinational pharma companies, which are therefore pleased to see the continuing development of Chinese innovative drugs. Also, China has review procedures for the export of technology platforms. Overall, countries may have review measures, but the overall globalization trend will remain intact. This has also prompted more Chinese companies to conduct multi-regional clinical trials (MRCTs) at the early clinical trial stage.

8. How are domestic clinical CROs building AI capability? Apart from statistical programming, what other applications are there?

Expert: With extensive applications, AI is enabling the entire value chain. In clinical trials, applications include protocol design, CRF design, document management, risk control and statistical programming. However, companies vary in building their presences. Multinational companies mostly cooperate with well-developed external platforms, improving overall efficiency 30-50%. Domestic CROs are smaller in scale and have limited investment, so they mostly build small tools for internal use. By comparison, EDC companies are more proactive in investing (their results can also be commercialised).

9. Roughly what percentage of revenue will clinical CROs' AI investment account for in 2026-27?

Expert: Among domestic CROs, leading CROs invest cRmb100-200m, taking up less than 5% of revenue; in general, CROs invest c1-2% of revenue.

10. How much clinical CRO work could be undertaken by AI? Which areas will be most affected?

Expert: This can be viewed by risk level: low-risk or risk-free work will be undertaken by AI; medium-risk work will still require full-process manual quality control; high-risk, highly individualised work will still require human involvement. AI involvement may be stronger in data management, biostatistics, pharmacovigilance, medical writing and translation. However, roles such as CRC/CRA that communicate with research institutions, which also involve legal and regulatory requirements, may not change fundamentally over the next five years.

11. What advantages/disadvantages do AI-enabled CROs have compared with traditional leading CROs?

Expert: In the short term, they are less likely to have revolutionary differentiated advantages. Mature CROs already have historical protocol libraries for reference, and all CRO companies are investing in AI-related capability.

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We believe the risks facing China's medtech industry include: 1) larger-than-expected price reductions and smaller-than-expected market share gains from medical device VBP programs; 2) weaker-than-expected demand from equipment renewal programs; 3) a greater-than-expected impact from the anti-corruption drive; 4) geopolitical risks affecting the supply chain of medical device products; and 5) slower-than-expected product R&D and technological breakthroughs.

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